

The Staff. 1889. Our aims. In *La Solidaridad*, vol. 1: 1889, trans. Guadalupe Fores-Ganzon, 3, 5. Pasig City: Fundación Santiago.

From 1889-1895, the newspaper *La Solidaridad* served as the mouthpiece of propagandists seeking reforms for the Philippines. In its 7-year publication history, the newspaper published various works on politics, economics, literature, and society, all with the aim of introducing to a wider audience an awareness of the Spanish colony known as the Philippines and the plight of its citizens under Spanish colonial rule.

In its first issue on 15 February 1889, the first article pronounced the aims of the newspaper. As can be read from this source, the propagandists underscored the importance of defending progress and fighting all forces that countered its development. This idea would serve as the basis for all succeeding efforts made by the propagandists on behalf of the Filipinos.

Excerpt:

Our aspirations are modest, very modest. Our program, aside from being simple, is clear: to combat reaction, to stop all retrogressive steps, to extol and adopt liberal ideas, to defend progress; in a word, to be a propagandist, above all, of democratic ideas in order to make these supreme in all nations here and across the seas.

The aims, therefore, of *La Solidaridad* are described as to collect, to gather, libertarian ideas which are manifested daily in the field of politics, science, art, literature, commerce, agriculture and industry.

We shall also discuss all problems relating to the general interest of the nation and seek solutions to those problems in high-level and democratic manner.

With regard to the Philippines, since she needs the most help, not being represented in the Cortes, we shall pay particular attention to the defense of her democratic rights, the accomplishment of which is our patriotic duty.

That nation of eight million souls should not, must not be the exclusive preserve of theocracy and traditionalism.

“The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines”

Graciano Lopez Jaena, one of the leading figures of the Propaganda Movement, wrote “The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines” which was published in *España en Filipinas* in 1887. Jaena was born in Jaro Iloilo on December 18, 1856. In 1880 he left for Spain to pursue medicine but did not finish his studies as he became too involved in

journalism and politics. Lopez Jaena was particularly known for impassioned speeches and articles that dealt with the problems in the Philippines. He was also known for his anti clerical attitude as seen in some of his writings criticizing the role of the friars in the management of the affairs in the Philippines. He became *La Solidaridad*'s first editor in 1889.

Lopez Jaena's "The Causes of the Distress of the Philippines" is an assessment of the problems in the Philippines. It identified the faults and shortcomings of the Spanish colonial administration particularly in education, economy, and colonial bureaucracy. The document elaborated how ineffectual the colonial government is in its duties in the colony. It also criticizes the instructions in many schools which focus more on religious education than on necessary knowledge that would help in the progress of the Philippines. Lopez Jaena also made some suggestions among which is the establishment of more free ports that would benefit the colonial economy.

The document cited here is an English translation of Lopez Jaena's original article compiled in *Graciano Lopez Jaena: Speeches, Articles, and Letters* by the National Historical Institute (NHI).

Excerpt:

After those mentioned in the preceding article, the most notable cause of the backwardness of the Philippines is the anomalous education given to the youth in schools. They learn to read correctly and to write gracefully, but they do not learn useful things because they are not taught any. They are taught how to pray but never to work.

In all public schools Spanish grammar is conspicuous by its absence, because certain people place obstacles to teaching the Indio Spanish, the elements of physics, chemistry, geography, and agriculture, knowledge of which is certainly useful to the future of the individual and the progress of the nation; but, if all these subjects are conspicuous by their absence, on the other hand, never absent are the rosary, trisagion, the thousand and one novenas of the saints, the Virgin and the martyrs with which the tender minds of the children are nourished spiritually and viciously.

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On the kind of instruction given in the Royal and Pontifical University, the seminaries and colleges we say nothing because it would be an inexhaustible subject.

The continuous change of personnel in the government is another cause of the havoc and

disasters in the Philippines and in the colonies in general. Such a swift change is only comparable to the locusts which, after devastating the fields, are replaced in swift and vertiginous succession. If to this is added the incompetence of the majority of the government personnel, it becomes evident that from progression to progression, the country in a short time reaches the apogee of her ruin.

The fatal omission of natives from the government positions of high or average importance is its corollary: the lack of any improvement in the Philippines, the towns remaining stagnant and backward. Since some of those who give orders, who govern and administer are inept and insecure in their posts, it matters little to them whether the country improves and advances or not.

We are not unaware that there exist royal decrees on the filling of the government positions with natives, but the truth is these are not followed and the law and everything else about this matter are a dead letter.

Another cause of the ruinous condition of the Archipelago is the Mint in Manila which turns out gold and silver coins that enrich China and the British colonies rather than the Philippines. The Chinese and the British export our gold and silver, the first to their country and the other to her colonies, paying "hard premium" in Mexican silver, common in the Islands, so that it has become very difficult to obtain in Manila four-peso gold coin.

The abolition of the existing differential duties, freedom of commerce, freedom of association, freedom of the press through which the Filipino may study or learn about the progress of all the branches of industry, commerce and agriculture for their own benefit and for that of their country, as well as how to convert China and Japan into markets for our products through the negotiation of commercial treaties with them, are the supreme remedies to reactivate and restore to life the already comatose Philippine commerce.

With regard to the Chinese, inasmuch as they have already joined the convert of nations, the powers ought to compel them to mint their own coins and adopt their own monetary system, for it is not fair that they should take advantage of the specie of every country. With their present commercial methods, it is impossible to transact business and exchange with them.

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Likewise, it is urgent to establish free ports for the benefit of the natives of the country, inasmuch as nature has created these ports for the use of the people who live in them. To go against nature is to violate natural law; it is to infringe on the very work of God. Human justice, policy, and government should act in conformity with, never against the laws of nature.

Álbum de Filipinas, ca. 1870, Biblioteca Nacional de España

The album is a collection of late-nineteenth-century photographs in the Philippines housed at the National Library of Spain (Biblioteca Nacional de España), Madrid, Spain. It consists of 17 portraits and 43 landscape photographs that offer a rich source of pictorial information on the socio-cultural, economic, and urban history of the last decades of Spanish rule in Manila and its nearby areas.¹⁵

The source provides a visual reconstruction and representation of the many facets of the Philippine colonial life. The different socio-economic and ethnic classes of colonial Philippines were illustrated through several portraits of the Spanish population, Spanish and Chinese mestizos, natives, other European inhabitants of Manila, as well as the Negritos in the province of Pampanga. Women history, social history, and sartorial studies could be gleaned from these visual sources. Also, the album provides supplementary pictorial sources on the Philippines' economic history in the late nineteenth century through some photos of the bustling port of Manila, the commercial activities along the Pasig river, the tobacco factory, etc. Moreover, it excellently depicts the urban built environment of the colonial capital and the dwellings found at the Pasig River's right and left bank. Manila's colonial modernity can be interrogated through the innovative structures and spaces introduced in Manila during the late nineteenth-century. The catalogue shows the modernization project of the city's port; rehabilitation of the Pasig River and surrounding estuaries; improvement of the inhabitants' mobility and communication through new bridges and paved and widened roads; and the city transformation with the introduction of *paseos* and plazas for the city's embellishment. Finally, the album can aid in discussing the Philippines' history of disasters through photos depicting some of the destruction in the capital caused by the 1863 earthquake and the reconstruction efforts on some of the primary colonial edifices and churches in Manila.